

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

STRATEGY

THE RHYTHM OF MANAGEMENT: THE DAY, THE WEEK, THE MONTH

How fragmented a manager's day is, where the time of chief executives goes, the daily, weekly and monthly routines that give it a shape, and a card for your own rhythm.



< 9 min

was how long half of the activities of the chief executives Mintzberg observed lasted; one in ten went past an hour.

MINTZBERG, 1975

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In this issue

A manager's week fills itself: calls, questions, problems that cannot wait. This issue is about the few fixed routines that keep the important things from being crowded out: a short daily check, a weekly conversation, a monthly look back.

Henry Mintzberg found that most of what chief executives did lasted minutes, not hours. Decades later, 27 CEOs spent 72% of their working time in meetings. Lean answers with standard work for leaders and short daily meetings in tiers; Andy Grove with a one-to-one of at least an hour. In a children's hospital, daily huddles were part of an effort that almost halved one kind of serious event, though never on their own.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure

Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading

Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice

The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Nine minutes

Henry Mintzberg followed five chief executives for a week each and recorded everything they did. In 1975 he summed up what he had seen in Harvard Business Review.

“Half the activities engaged in by the five chief executives of my study lasted less than nine minutes, and only 10% exceeded one hour.”

5

chief executives, one week each

1/2

of their activities lasted less than nine minutes

10%

lasted more than an hour

Mintzberg set the folklore of the calm, systematic planner against what he saw: work that was brief, varied and constantly interrupted, and that leaned towards action rather than reflection.

OUR READING

If the day is cut into nine-minute pieces, the important things need fixed places. Otherwise the urgent ones take them all.

Source: Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975

THE NUMBERS

Where 60,000 hours went

Michael Porter and Nitin Nohria had the assistants of 27 CEOs log their time, around the clock, in 15-minute blocks, for 13 weeks: nearly 60,000 hours. The CEOs worked 62.5 hours a week on average.

SHARE OF THE CEOS' WORKING TIME

Reviews of units and functions	25%
People and relationships	25%
Strategy	21%
Organisation and culture	16%

72%

of working time in meetings

43%

on work that advanced their own agenda

36%

reacting to issues as they came up

OUR READING

Even at the top, more than a third of the time goes to reacting. A fixed rhythm is what keeps the rest from going the same way.

Source: Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018

The four areas are shares of all working time and do not add up to 100%.

THE MODEL

A rhythm in three beats

In Creating a Lean Culture, David Mann names four elements of lean management: standard work for leaders, visual controls, a daily accountability process and discipline. Andy Grove adds the weekly conversation.

- | | | |
|-----------|---|---|
| 01 | The day: short meetings in tiers | The team at the start of the shift, then the supervisors, then the managers: a problem travels up the same morning. |
| 02 | The week: one-to-ones | At least an hour, with an agenda the employee prepares; more often with someone new to the task, less often with a veteran. |
| 03 | The month: a look back | The numbers of the month, what the daily meetings kept bringing up, and one change for the next month. |

Mann estimated that standard work fills about 80% of a team leader's day. Higher up it fills less, and more of the time goes to following up the level below.

OUR READING

A rhythm is not more meetings. It is fewer, at fixed times, each with one job.

Sources: David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005; Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006; Andrew S. Grove, 1983

The day follows Mann, the week Grove; the monthly look back is the editors'.

More in the essay

Ten minutes before the shift: what the team needs to know before the work starts

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

What a daily huddle can do

A children's hospital with 539 beds introduced short daily meetings in three tiers: on the wards, among managers and among leaders. They looked ahead at risks, reported safety events and moved resources where they were needed.

UNRECOGNISED DETERIORATION ENDING IN INTENSIVE CARE, PER 10,000 PATIENT DAYS

4.4

2.4

Before

After

The fall came from a bundle of measures: spotting risk early, frequent huddles of the whole care team, and ways of learning from each event. There was no control group, so the share of the huddles cannot be separated. A second study of the same hospital, based on 10 interviews and 6 focus groups, described how the huddles worked but measured no outcome.

OUR READING

A daily huddle is cheap. Its value is in what happens after it: the problem that someone takes away and closes.

Sources: Patrick W. Brady et al., *Pediatrics*, 2013; Linda M. Goldenhar et al., *BMJ Quality & Safety*, 2013

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Check the rhythm, not the calendar

In Mann's system, standard work is written down and the level above checks whether it happened. The same works for your own routines.

- 1 Write the routines down**
Each beat with a time, a place and an owner.
- 2 Mark each one, every day**
Held or not, in one line.
- 3 Count once a month**
The share held, and why the others fell away.
- 4 Change one thing**
Move, shorten or drop the routine that keeps failing.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEAD'S MONTH

Daily	19 of 22 meetings held
Weekly	5 of 8 one-to-ones held
Monthly	1 of 1 review held

The weekly beat is the one that breaks, so that is where the change goes. The numbers are invented.

Source: Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006

The steps and the example are the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The rhythm card

One card for the routines of your role. Fill it in once, keep it where you work, and check it at the end of each week.

01 Every day time, place, ten minutes, who attends

02 What the daily meeting looks at safety, yesterday's numbers, today's risks

03 Every week one-to-ones: with whom, how long, who brings the agenda

04 Every month the review: which numbers, which question

05 What I stop doing to make room for the routines

06 Who checks me the person who sees whether the routines happened

Sources: David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005; Andrew S. Grove, 1983

A practice proposed by the editors, after Mann's daily accountability and Grove's one-to-ones.

Open the tool: [Shift Pulse](#)

stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-pulse/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The Manager's Job: Folklore and Fact

Henry Mintzberg, Harvard Business Review, 1975

<https://hbr.org/1990/03/the-managers-job-folklore-and-fact>

How CEOs Manage Time

Michael E. Porter & Nitin Nohria, Harvard Business Review, 2018

<https://hbr.org/2018/07/how-ceos-manage-time>

Creating a Lean Culture: Tools to Sustain Lean Conversions

David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005

Creating a Lean Culture That Lasts: A Conversation with David Mann

Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast, 2006

<https://www.leanblog.org/2006/11/creating-a-lean-culture-david-mann/>

High Output Management

Andrew S. Grove, 1983

Huddling for high reliability and situation awareness

Linda M. Goldenhar et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2013

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23744537/>

Improving situation awareness to reduce unrecognized clinical deterioration and serious safety events

Patrick W. Brady et al., Pediatrics, 2013

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23230078/>

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked "via". The editors' interpretation is marked "Our reading". Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html